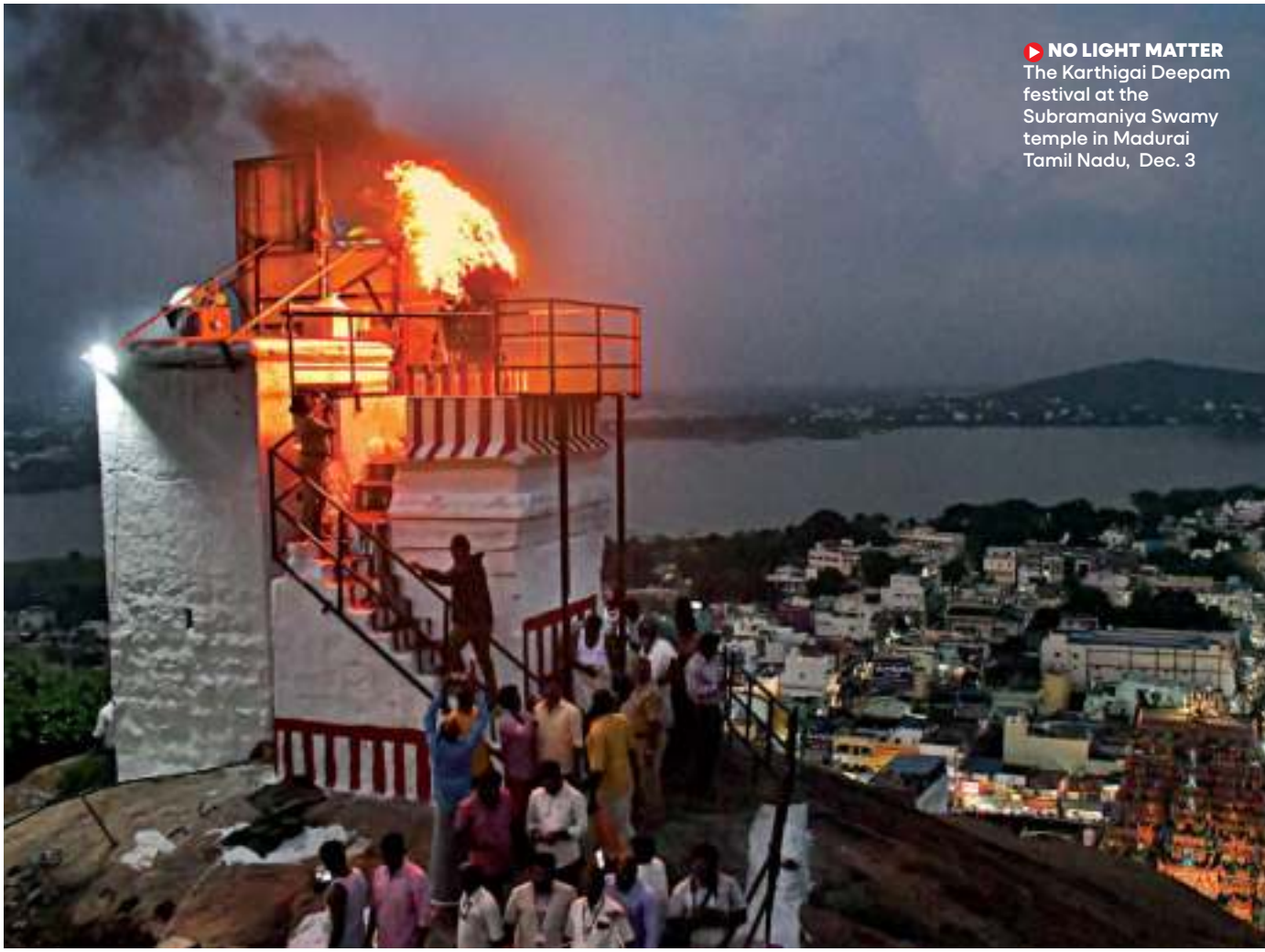


NO LIGHT MATTER
The Karthigai Deepam festival at the Subramaniya Swamy temple in Madurai Tamil Nadu, Dec. 3

PTI

tion from supposed encroachment. A petitioner approached the Madras High Court, seeking to shift the ritual from the temple to the *deepathoonu*, claiming that to be the original site.

REOPENING THE DISPUTE

No historical evidence exists to support the claim. In contrast, extensive official documentation identifies the structure as a theodolite pillar forming part of the Great Trigonometrical Survey's British-era mapping station. Its hollow top, cited as a place for oil storage, was in fact engineered to stabilise surveying instruments. Anyway, in 1996, the court disallowed the plea and held the temple to be the "traditional place" for the ritual, while allowing devotees to light lamps on the hill, away from the dargah. Later pleas were met with judicial recusal from altering the status quo.

A petitioner has now reopened the litigation—this time with greater success. On December 1, Justice G.R. Swaminathan permitted lamp-lighting at the pillar. On December 3, the festival day, the state refused to play ball. A volley of contempt pleas and counter-affidavits followed. In Delhi, INDIA bloc MPs led by Priyanka Gandhi and Akhilesh Yadav filed an impeachment motion against the judge on December 9, calling his conduct "partial and ideological"—a move Union home minister Amit Shah castigated as "appeasement politics". Back in Madurai, S. Venkatesan—local MP, Tamil writer and CPI(M) young turk—says the BJP is turning the sacred Karthigai Deepam into "a flame of conflict". But new state BJP chief Nainar Nagendran, an AIADMK export, feels it's time to import "an Ayodhya" into poll-bound Tamil Nadu. ■

Takeaways

- **A single-judge HC bench allows lamp-lighting ritual near hilltop dargah**
- **Tradition, court rulings, recorded history—all three sanctify temple as original site for Karthigai Deepam**
- **INDIA bloc moves for judge's impeachment**